PROJECTS & CASE STUDIES

INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS | UK

GYM SHARK

Community-Led Social Media & Meta Ads Growth Strategy

Market research | Customer psychology | Positioning | Paid social funnel

BUSINESS	Gymshark (fitness apparel, direct-to-consumer)
RESEARCH TOPIC	Scaling community trust into profitable paid social growth worldwide
PREPARED BY	Shakir Hossain Talha
ROLE	Digital Marketing Manager | Social Media Marketing Strategist
RESEARCH DATE	05 February 2025

Independent strategic research based on publicly observable brand activity. Not affiliated with or commissioned by the brand.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

THE BIG IDEA

Gymshark grew by acting like a community first and a retailer second. The next growth chapter needs the same community energy turned into a repeatable, measurable paid social system across many countries and cultures.

Objective: keep brand love high while lowering the cost of acquiring and retaining customers.

01 **Community is the moat**
Anyone can sell leggings. Few can make people feel they belong to a team.

02 **Creators are the creative engine**
Authentic athlete content outperforms polished brand ads when used in paid media.

03 **Drops create urgency**
Limited releases and launches give paid social a natural reason to act now.

WHAT THIS CASE STUDY COVERS

1. Brand DNA and business model
2. Competitor map across 4 rival types
3. Customer identity ladder and drivers
4. Social flywheel and platform roles
5. Full-funnel Meta Ads + testing matrix
6. KPI framework and 90-day roadmap

NOTE ON DATA Findings come from desk research of public social profiles, ad libraries, product drops and customer conversation. KPI numbers are planning benchmarks to validate in a test phase, not company data.

BRAND DNA & BUSINESS MODEL

2012
Founded in the UK by Ben Francis, starting as a small online fitness apparel brand.

SOCIAL FIRST
Grew through early creators, gym culture content and a strong community voice.

DTC MODEL
Direct-to-consumer e-commerce gives control of brand, data and customer relationship.

GLOBAL + PHYSICAL
Expanded to many markets and added selective physical retail and community events.

FOUR BRAND PILLARS

Community
Belonging to a tribe that trains together and shares progress.

Creators
Real athletes and creators as trusted voices, not just models.

Product Fit
Performance + style that works for gym and daily life.

Culture of Progress
Challenges and stories about getting better, not being perfect.

SWOT SNAPSHOT

STRENGTHS
Loyal community, creator network, strong brand voice, DTC data

WEAKNESSES
Reliance on paid social and drops; sizing and fit feedback

OPPORTUNITIES
New markets, women's range, retail experiences, loyalty

THREATS
Rising ad costs, giants like Nike and lululemon, privacy changes

COMPETITOR LANDSCAPE

POSITIONING MAP (conceptual)



GLOBAL SPORTS GIANTS
Nike, Adidas, Under Armour
Edge: Scale, athlete sponsors, innovation
Our angle: Closer community feel and faster social-native content

PREMIUM ATHLEISURE
lululemon, Alo Yoga
Edge: Premium status, store experience
Our angle: Accessible price with strong fit and style

SUBSCRIPTION / D2C RIVALS
Fabletics and others
Edge: Membership offers, big promos
Our angle: Creators and community, not just discounts

FAST-MOVING ONLINE BRANDS
Many Instagram-born labels
Edge: Trend speed, low price
Our angle: Brand trust, quality, community identity

THE WHITE SPACE
Premium-feeling performance wear that still feels like a friendly community, not a corporate sports giant. Gymshark should own the 'community-powered fitness brand' position.

THE IDENTITY LADDER

People buy fitness wear to become someone. Each step of the journey needs different messaging.

1 THE STARTER

Wants to begin without feeling judged.

Fear: looking out of place.

Message: you belong here from day one.

Content: first-day-in-the-gym guides, beginner stories.

2 THE CONSISTENT

Building habit and tracking progress.

Fear: losing motivation.

Message: progress beats perfection.

Content: 30-day challenges, habit and routine reels.

3 THE COMMITTED ATHLETE

Performance, fit and durability matter.

Fear: gear that fails mid-session.

Message: built for your hardest sets.

Content: athlete training breakdowns, honest gear tests.

4 THE COMMUNITY LEADER

Shares journey, inspires others.

Fear: not being seen or recognised.

Message: be part of the team, lead it.

Content: community spotlights, event films, creator features.

PSYCHOLOGICAL DRIVERS TO USE IN CONTENT & ADS

- Belonging
- Self-improvement
- Social proof
- Status & identity
- Scarcity (drops)

SOCIAL FLYWHEEL & PLATFORM ROLES



INSTAGRAM
Brand home: Reels, creator collabs, drops, stories. Main discovery + conversion engine.

TIKTOK
Trend-native short videos, challenges, gym culture humour. Top-of-funnel reach.

YOUTUBE
Longer athlete stories, training series, event films. Deep trust-building.

FACEBOOK + MESSENGER
Retargeting at scale, broad Meta delivery, customer service touchpoints.

EMAIL / SMS / COMMUNITY
Owned audience for drops, early access and loyalty.

Creators spark trust, community adds belonging, user content proves it, paid media scales the winners, drops convert demand. Results feed the next cycle.

META ADS FUNNEL & TESTING MATRIX

AWARENESS
Reach / Video views

Creator reels, challenge content

KPIs: CPM, 3-sec view rate

CONSIDERATION
Traffic / Engagement

Product demos, fit and review videos

KPIs: CTR, CPC, landing views

CONVERSION
Sales (catalog)

Dynamic ads, offers, drop countdowns

KPIs: CVR, CPA, ROAS

RETENTION
Sales / Retargeting

New drops, loyalty, early access

KPIs: Repeat rate, LTV

CREATIVE TESTING MATRIX (test one variable at a time)

HOOK	Pain point | Result first | Social proof | Curiosity
FORMAT	Creator reel | UGC review | Carousel | Static lookbook
OFFER	Drop access | Bundle | Free shipping threshold | No discount
AUDIENCE	Broad | Lookalike | Interest stack | Retargeting

BUDGET LOGIC (planning)

Prospecting	55%
Retargeting	30%
Testing	15%

KPIS & 90-DAY ROADMAP

AWARENESS	ENGAGEMENT	CONVERSION	PROFIT	LOYALTY
CPM, reach, 3-sec view rate	CTR, saves, shares, comments	CVR, CPA, add-to-cart rate	ROAS vs break-even ROAS, AOV	Repeat rate, LTV, CAC payback

Targets are set per market after a 2-week learning phase. Benchmarks are assumptions, not company data.

90-DAY ROADMAP

DAYS 1-30
FOUNDATION

- Audit pixel, catalog, events
- Map audiences by market
- Build creator brief library
- Launch 3-audience test

DAYS 31-60
TEST & LEARN

- Hook and format A/B tests
- Scale winning creator ads
- Start retargeting funnel
- Weekly KPI report

DAYS 61-90
SCALE & RETAIN

- Scale proven ad sets
- UGC / creator programme
- Drop-based loyalty flows
- Quarterly review + plan

REPORTING & OPTIMISATION RHYTHM

DAILY
Spend pacing, delivery issues, CPA alerts

WEEKLY
Creative review, kill / scale decisions, test read-outs

MONTHLY
ROAS, LTV, audience refresh, strategy reset

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I research the market, decode customer psychology, sharpen positioning and turn it into measurable paid social growth. This case study shows how I think.

Market Research | Customer Psychology | Brand Positioning | Meta Ads



SIGNATURE

Shakir Hossain Talha

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